

Rethinking case attraction on Ancient Greek infinitive clauses

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1 Introduction

Good morning. The reasons behind why the pair of sentences in (1) show different agreement/concord patterns remains largely unknown.

- (1) a. συμβουλεύει τῷ Ξενοφῶντι ἐλθόντα εἰς Δελφοὺς ἀνακοινῶσαι τῷ θεῷ περὶ τῆς πορείας.
He advises Xenophon to go to Delphi and ask the god about the travel. (Xen. *Anab.* 3.1.5)
- b. ἀφῆκε μοι ἐλθόντι πρὸς ὑμᾶς λέγειν ἀληθῆ.
He allowed me to go and speak the truth in front of you. (Xen. *Hell.* 6.1.13)

[Self-deprecatingly] I myself have, in the last edition of this event, tried to present the patterns that make the attraction result, (1-b), more likely, arguing that the classes of the matrix and infinitive verbs and the relative distance and position of the controller and target of agreement were the most important factors.

Furthermore, I argued that these factors were but *proxies* to unseen variables, namely semantic and pragmatic features of the discourse setting, and that even in the absence of seen contrasting factors, precisely the case in the pair above (1), the unseen discourse factors would be still causing one resolution to be at the very least more likely.

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[Introducingly] I wasn't, however, quite convinced about neither the methods, data, and, most of all, quality of the results I arrived at. So this will be a more rigorous tentative to approach the problem.

The aim of this paper is to walk through the assumptions present in my own and other's assessments of the phenomenon, as I believe most of them are in themselves right, build from these assumptions a causal system and show how much of this system is left unexplained with what we do know and, more importantly, I believe, what we **can** know and measure about ancient languages in general.

2 Nature of attraction

In the most abstract way possible, case attraction in infinitive clauses, exemplified by (1-b), is when two constituents, a controller and a target, produced in different domains of a sentence, one of the domains encompassing the other, covary in an specific feature, namely [*Case*].

This satisfies the definition of agreement in Corbett's typological assessment of the phenomenon across languages (2006, pp. 4–7).

The lack of covariation of the [*Case*] feature, seen in (1-a), is generally understood as result of the application of **default** case concord rules of Ancient Greek. This assumes that the subject of infinitive clauses in Greek is always marked as accusative, even when not overtly expressed, and that convert constituents are also marked for [*Case*] and its case is also available for nominal concord.

The facts that the target has a choice of controller (either the overt oblique or de convert accusative) for agreement, that [*Case*] is a non-lexical features, that the agreement is optional, and that the domain is non-local favours the interpretation that the agreement type of case attraction is less canonical than the general agreement type of Ancient Greek, following the criteria for canonical agreement in the same work of Corbett (2006, pp. 8ff.).

If this assessment is sound, it is expected that attraction and non-attraction behave as different resolutions of agreement, the former being less canonical and thus more likely to be conditioned. Tipologically, factors favouring non-canonical agreement resolutions include: animacy, thematic roles and grammatical relation of the controller, relative word order and distance (precedence of the target), communicative function, definiteness, and predication class.

References

CORBETT, G. G. (2006). *Agreement*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

A Criteria for Canonical Agreement

The following list summarizes the criteria for canonical agreement as discussed in section 1.4 of Corbett (2006, pp. 8ff.). The underlines indicate what position in the hierarchy case attraction arguably occupies.

- Controllers:
 - C-1: controller present > controller absent
 - C-2: controller has overt expression of agreement features > controller has covert expression of agreement features
 - * “A canonical controller marks at least as many distinctions as the target”
 - C-3: consistent controller > hybrid controller
 - C-4: controller’s part of speech is irrelevant > is relevant (given the domain)
- Targets:
 - C-5: inflectional marking (affix) > clitic > free word
 - C-6: obligatory > optional
 - C-7: regular > suppletive
 - C-8: alliterative > opaque
 - C-9: productive marking of agreement > sporadic marking
 - C-10: target always agree > target agrees only when controller is absent
 - C-11: target agrees with a single controller > agrees with more than one controller
 - C-12: target has no choice of controller > target has choice of controller (is ‘trigger-happy’)
 - C-13: target’s part of speech is irrelevant > is relevant (given the domain)
- Domains:
 - C-14: asymmetric > symmetric
 - C-15: local domain > non-local domain
 - C-16: domain is one of a set > single domain
- Features:
 - C-17: feature is lexical > non-lexical
 - C-18: features have matching values > non-matching values
 - C-19: no choice of feature value > choice of value
- Conditions:
 - C-20: no conditions > conditions